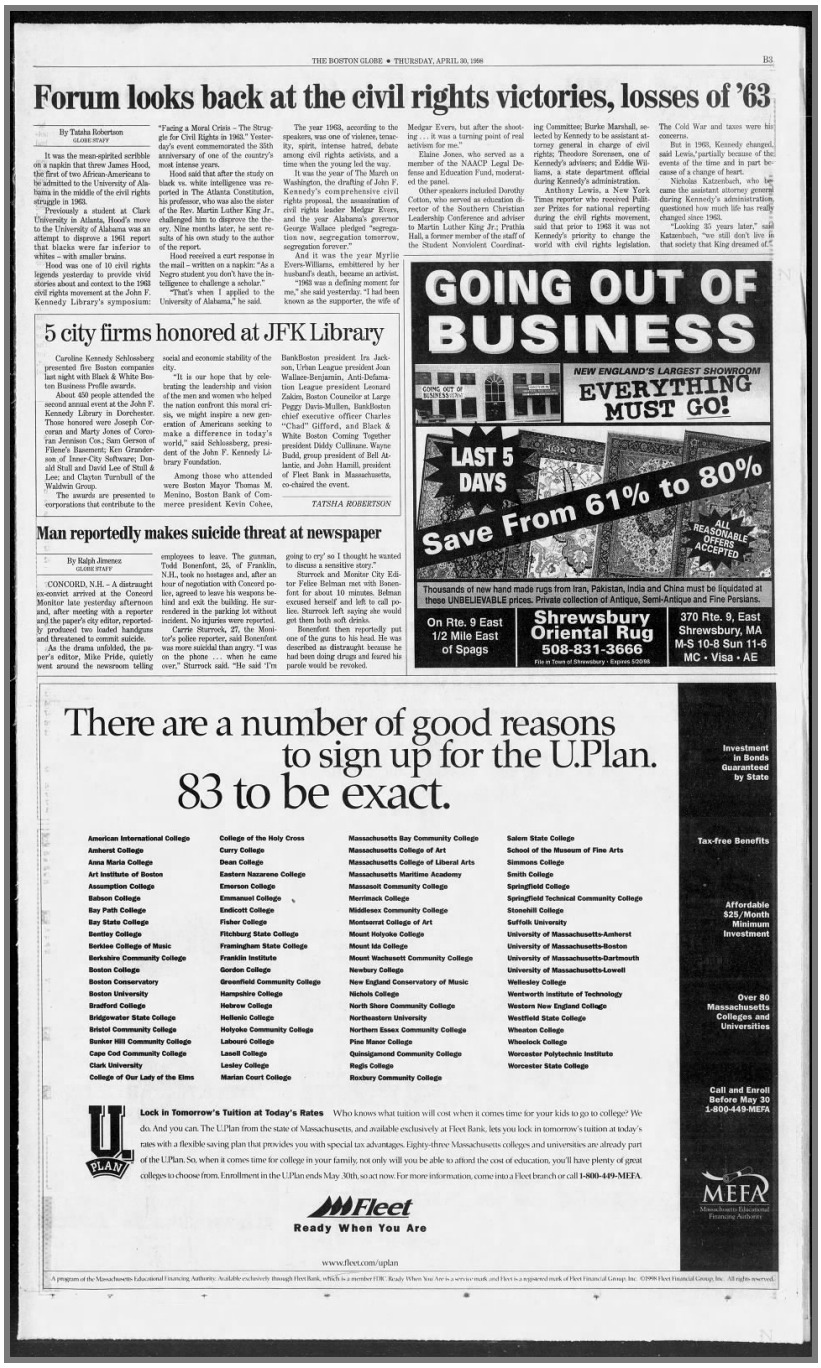
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Forum looks back at the civil rights victories, losses of '63

By Tatsha Robertson
GLOBE STAFF

It was the mean-spirited scribble on a napkin that threw James Hood, the first of two African-Americans to be admitted to the University of Alabama in the middle of the civil rights struggle in 1963.

Previously a student at Clark University in Atlanta, Hood's move to the University of Alabama was an attempt to disprove a 1961 report that blacks were far inferior to whites – with smaller brains.

Hood was one of 10 civil rights legends yesterday to provide vivid stories about and context to the 1963 civil rights movement at the John F. Kennedy Library's symposium: "Facing a Moral Crisis – The Struggle for Civil Rights in 1963." Yesterday's event commemorated the 35th anniversary of one of the country's most intense years.

Hood said that after the study on black vs. white intelligence was reported in The Atlanta Constitution, his professor, who was also the sister of the Rev. Martin Luther King Jr., challenged him to disprove the theory. Nine months later, he sent results of his own study to the author of the report.

Hood received a curt response in the mail – written on a napkin: "As a Negro student you don't have the intelligence to challenge a scholar."

"That's when I applied to the University of Alabama," he said.

The year 1963, according to the speakers, was one of violence, tenacity, spirit, intense hatred, debate among civil rights activists, and a time when the young led the way.

It was the year of The March on Washington, the drafting of John F. Kennedy's comprehensive civil rights proposal, the assassination of civil rights leader Medgar Evers, and the year Alabama's governor George Wallace pledged "segregation now, segregation tomorrow, segregation forever."

And it was the year Myrlie Evers-Williams, embittered by her husband's death, became an activist.

"1963 was a defining moment for me," she said yesterday. "I had been known as the supporter, the wife of Medgar Evers, but after the shooting . . . it was a turning point of real activism for me."

Elaine Jones, who served as a member of the NAACP Legal Defense and Education Fund, moderated the panel.

Other speakers included Dorothy Cotton, who served as education director of the Southern Christian Leadership Conference and adviser to Martin Luther King Jr.; Prathia Hall, a former member of the staff of the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee; Burke Marshall, selected by Kennedy to be assistant attorney general in charge of civil rights; Theodore Sorensen, one of Kennedy's advisers; and Eddie Williams, a state department official during Kennedy's administration.

Anthony Lewis, a New York Times reporter who received Pulitzer Prizes for national reporting during the civil rights movement, said that prior to 1963 it was not Kennedy's priority to change the world with civil rights legislation. The Cold War and taxes were his concerns.

But in 1963, Kennedy changed, said Lewis,"partially because of the events of the time and in part because of a change of heart.

Nicholas Katzenbach, who became the assistant attorney general during Kennedy's administration, questioned how much life has really changed since 1963.

"Looking 35 years later," said Katzenbach, "we still don't live in that society that King dreamed of."

5 city firms honored at JFK Library

Caroline Kennedy Schlossberg presented five Boston companies last night with Black & White Boston Business Profile awards.

About 450 people attended the second annual event at the John F. Kennedy Library in Dorchester. Those honored were Joseph Corcoran and Marty Jones of Corcoran Jennison Cos.; Sam Gerson of Filene's Basement; Ken Granderson of Inner-City Software; Donald Stull and David Lee of Stull & Lee; and Clayton Turnbull of the Waldwin Group.

The awards are presented to corporations that contribute to the social and economic stability of the city.

"It is our hope that by celebrating the leadership and vision of the men and women who helped the nation confront this moral crisis, we might inspire a new generation of Americans seeking to make a difference in today's world," said Schlossberg, president of the John F. Kennedy Library Foundation.

Among those who attended were Boston Mayor Thomas M. Menino, Boston Bank of Commerce president Kevin Cohee, BankBoston president Ira Jackson, Urban League president Joan Wallace-Benjamin, Anti-Defamation League president Leonard Zakim, Boston Councilor at Large Peggy Davis-Mullen, BankBoston chief executive officer Charles "Chad" Gifford, and Black & White Boston Coming Together president Diddy Cullinane. Wayne Budd, group president of Bell Atlantic, and John Hamill, president of Fleet Bank in Massachusetts, co-chaired the event.

TATSHA ROBERTSON

Man reportedly makes suicide threat at newspaper

By Ralph Jimenez
GLOBE STAFF

CONCORD, N.H. – A distraught ex-convict arrived at the Concord Monitor late yesterday afternoon and, after meeting with a reporter and the paper's city editor, reportedly produced two loaded handguns and threatened to commit suicide.

As the drama unfolded, the paper's editor, Mike Pride, quietly went around the newsroom telling employees to leave. The gunman, Todd Bonenfont, 25, of Franklin, N.H., took no hostages and, after an hour of negotiation with Concord police, agreed to leave his weapons behind and exit the building. He surrendered in the parking lot without incident. No injuries were reported.

Carrie Sturrock, 27, the Monitor's police reporter, said Bonenfont was more suicidal than angry. "I was on the phone … when he came over," Sturrock said. "He said 'I'm going to cry' so I thought he wanted to discuss a sensitive story."

Sturrock and Monitor City Editor Felice Belman met with Bonenfont for about 10 minutes. Belman excused herself and left to call police. Sturrock left saying she would get them both soft drinks.

Bonenfont then reportedly put one of the guns to his head. He was described as distraught because he had been doing drugs and feared his parole would be revoked.

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